

Autonomous Physics-Based Modeling of Retention Loss in 3-D NAND Flash Memories

Myung Jin and , *Member, IEEE*

Abstract—A novel model is established with physical derivation in retention operation of 3-D NAND flash memory. To efficiently incorporate the retention loss properties of the immediate and continuous occurrence, an autonomous model has been suggested. By utilizing the model, retention loss for both short-term and long-term due to detrapping effect of trapped electron can be simulated in very short timeframe. Moreover, autonomous model makes it possible for model to predict the time transient of ΔV_{th} by only using an initial condition.

Index Terms—Bandgap-Engineered 3D NAND Flash, Soft Program, Pass Voltage, ΔV_T Distribution

I. INTRODUCTION

THERE rapid increase in data storage demand, driven by emerging computing technologies such as artificial intelligence (AI) and high-performance computing (HPC), has raised significant concerns about the reliability of 3-D NAND flash memories, particularly regarding retention loss.

As the storage capacity per cell continues to increase, it becomes essential to maintain the reliability of each bit's threshold voltage distribution over extended periods, ranging from several days to multiple years.

Previous studies have reported that charge detrapping can occur even under cryogenic conditions, which is consistent with earlier models assuming temperature-independent detrapping behavior.

In this study, an autonomous model for retention loss based on tunneling emission mechanisms in 3-D NAND flash memory is developed. The proposed simulation framework requires only the initial condition as input and enables highly efficient computation with significantly reduced simulation time.

II. MODELING

This section presents the modeling framework for autonomous simulation of retention loss.

First, a cylindrical Poisson solution is derived for the oxide–nitride–oxide (O/N/O) gate stack, incorporating quantized multiple layers within the charge trap nitride (CTN) layer. After obtaining the detailed Poisson solution for these discretized layers, the threshold voltage shift (ΔV_{th}) is calculated using an optimized numerical scheme. Finally, based on previous

studies of detrapping-induced emission rates, an autonomous equation governing retention loss behavior is proposed.

A. Detailed Poisson Solution

An electrical potential distribution obtained from the cylindrical Poisson equation for discretized layers in the ONO structure can be expressed as follows.

$$\begin{cases} V_{Si}(r_{Si}) = V_{ch} \\ V_{TOX}(r) = V_{ch} + \frac{K_{TOX}}{\epsilon_{TOX}} \ln \frac{r}{r_{Si}} \\ V_{CTN,i}(r) = V_{CTN,i-1}(r_{i-1}) + \frac{K_i}{\epsilon_{CTN}} \ln \frac{r}{r_{i-1}} \\ V_{BOX}(r) = V_{CTN,N}(r_N) + \frac{K_{BOX}}{\epsilon_{BOX}} \ln \frac{r}{r_N} \\ V_{BOX}(r_{BOX}) = V_G \end{cases} \quad (1)$$

where $i = 1-N$ denotes the index of each discretized slice of the CTN layer in the radial direction, and N is the total number of radial partitions.

Solving $\mathbf{x}$ vector can calculate the total $N + 2$ potential parameters.

$$\mathbf{x} = [K_{TOX} \quad K_1 \quad \cdots \quad K_N \quad K_{BOX}]^T \quad (2)$$

$$\mathbf{A}\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b} \quad (3)$$

Matrix $\mathbf{A}$ and vector $\mathbf{b}$ are constructed by enforcing a total of $N+1$ transverse electric field continuity conditions ($\epsilon_1 \mathcal{E}_1 = \epsilon_2 \mathcal{E}_2$) together with an additional boundary condition defined by reference potential.

$$\mathbf{A} = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & -1 & 0 & \cdots & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & \cdots & 0 & 0 \\ \vdots & & & \ddots & & \vdots \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & \cdots & 1 & -1 \\ \frac{2\pi}{C_{TOX}} & \frac{2\pi}{C_1} & \frac{2\pi}{C_2} & \cdots & \frac{2\pi}{C_N} & \frac{2\pi}{C_{BOX}} \end{bmatrix} \quad (4)$$

$$\mathbf{b} = [\frac{\Delta Q_0}{2\pi} \quad \frac{\Delta Q_1}{2\pi} \quad \cdots \quad \frac{\Delta Q_N}{2\pi} \quad \Delta V]^T \quad (5)$$

$$\Delta Q_i = \pi r_i^2 (n_{t,i} - n_{t,i-1}) \quad (6)$$

$$\Delta V = (V_G - V_{ch}) - \sum_{i=1}^N \frac{qn_{t,i}}{4\epsilon_{CTN}} (r_i^2 - r_{i-1}^2) \quad (7)$$

C_{TOX} , C_i , and C_{BOX} in (4) denote the capacitances of each cylindrical layer, as illustrated in Fig. 1(c). ΔQ_i in (5)

Myung Jin is with the Seoul National University(e-mail: gsjb1028@snu.ac.kr).

S. B. Author, Jr., was with Rice University, Houston, TX 77005 USA. He is now with the Department of Physics, Colorado State University, Fort Collins, CO 80523 USA (e-mail: author@lamar.colostate.edu).

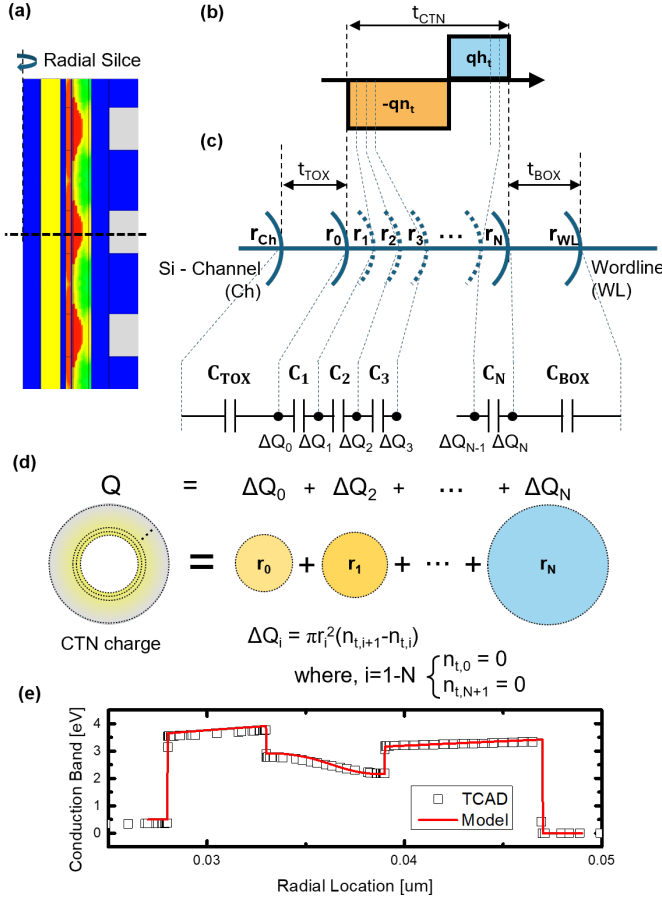


Fig. 1. (a) shows a radial scale and capacitance visualization, (b) shows the representation of ΔQ_i within the boundary condition solution, (c) shows the programming sequence of trapped electrons and holes, and (d) shows the autonomous simulation schematics.

represents the charge component associated with the cylindrical shell at radius r_i , which can be superpositioned as $Q = \sum \Delta Q_i$ as demonstrated on Fig. 1(d). Furthermore, (5) indicates that $b(\Delta Q_i, V_G - V_{ch})$ varies with the trapped charge distribution and the applied voltage conditions.

B. $Q - \Delta V_{th}$ Relation

For the ΔV_{th} calculation, the gate voltage difference required to maintain equal channel field conditions must be determined.

$$F_{TOX}(r_{Si}) = \frac{K_{TOX}}{\epsilon_{TOX}} \frac{1}{r_{Si}} \quad (8)$$

To achieve equal channel field conditions, the same K_{TOX} value under the given conditions must be established. By Cramer's rule, the K_{TOX} parameter can be solved through determinant calculation.

$$K_{TOX} = \frac{\det [A_{b(\Delta Q_i, \Delta V_{th})}]}{\det A} \quad (9)$$

where notation $A_{b(\Delta Q_i, \Delta V_{th})}$ stands for 1st column of matrix A replaced with vector $b(\Delta Q_i, \Delta V_{th})$.

Therefore, establishing following equation and solving for ΔV_{th} is needed to calculate the value.

$$\det [A_{b(0, \Delta V_{th})}] = \det [A_{b(\Delta Q_i, 0)}] \quad (10)$$

TABLE I
PARAMETER VALUES FOR THE TCAD SIMULATION

Symbol	Physical meaning	Value
r_f	Oxide filler radius	20 nm [?]
t_{Si}	Si-channel thickness	8 nm [?]
t_{TOX}	Tunneling oxide thickness	5 nm [?]
t_{CTN}	Charge trap nitride thickness	6 nm [?]
t_{BOX}	Blocking oxide thickness	8 nm [?]
ϵ_{ox}	Oxide permittivity	$3.9 \epsilon_0$ [?]
ϵ_{CTN}	Charge trap nitride permittivity	$7.5 \epsilon_0$ [?]
$\Delta \Phi_{Si-ox}$	Si-ox layer energy barrier height	3.1 eV [?]
$\Delta \Phi_{CTN-ox}$	CTN-ox layer energy barrier height	1 eV [?]
$\Delta \Phi_{WL-ox}$	WL-ox layer energy barrier height	3.65 eV [?]
m_{ox}^*	The effective mass of oxide	$0.5 m_0$ [?]
m_n^*	The effective mass of nitride	$0.4 m_0$ [?]
σ_n	electron capture cross section	$1 \times 10^{-16} \text{ cm}^2$ [?]
$\mu_{n,h}$	carrier mobility	$1 \times 10^{-4} \text{ cm}^2/\text{V} \cdot \text{s}$ [?]
V_{pass}	Pass voltage for untarget cell	7.0 V [?]
$V_{pgm,1}$	Program voltage for $\Delta V_{th} = 1 \text{ V}$	19.6 V

by property of multilinearity, $\det [A_{b(0, \Delta V_{th})}]$ in equation (10) can be calculated as following.

$$\det \begin{bmatrix} 0 & -1 & 0 & \cdots & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & \cdots & 0 & 0 \\ \vdots & & & \ddots & & \vdots \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & \cdots & 1 & -1 \\ \Delta V_{th} & \frac{2\pi}{C_1} & \frac{2\pi}{C_2} & \cdots & \frac{2\pi}{C_N} & \frac{2\pi}{C_{BOX}} \end{bmatrix} = -\Delta V_{th} \quad (11)$$

$$\therefore \Delta V_{th} = -\det [A_{b(\Delta Q_i, 0)}] \quad (12)$$

The threshold voltage difference can be calculated with single determinant computation with initially programmed trapped charge distribution is given as Fig. 1(d).

C. Autonomous Detrapping Modeling

With the given initial conditions, an autonomous equation is established for each cell, divided by radial position and trap depth as shown in Fig. 1(e).

$$\frac{d}{dt} n_t(r, E_t, t) = -(e_{ch} + e_{WL}) n_t(r, E_t, t) \quad (13)$$

Then, detrapping relation can be express as following general ODE solution.

$$n_t(r, E_t, t) = \sum_r \sum_{E_t} n_{t0}(r, E_t) \exp(-(e_{ch} + e_{WL})t) \quad (14)$$

The emission rate for trapped electron and hole can be computed as following equations based on a previous study [1].

$$e = \nu \times |TC| \quad (15)$$

$$\nu = \frac{2\pi}{h} |E_t|^2 V_{trap} \cdot \frac{m^* \sqrt{2m^*}}{\pi^2 \hbar^3} \sqrt{E - E_{trap}} \quad (16)$$

$$|TC| = \prod \exp \frac{4\sqrt{2m^*} \Phi_H^{1.5} - \Phi_L^{1.5}}{3\hbar q F} \quad (17)$$

for both channel and wordline directions as demonstrated in Fig. 1(a).

This autonomous detrapping modeling methodology enables a simulation to directly comput the result at a specific time without performing any transient time-interval calculations. Only the initial condition and the target time are required, eliminating the need for time-stepped simulations.

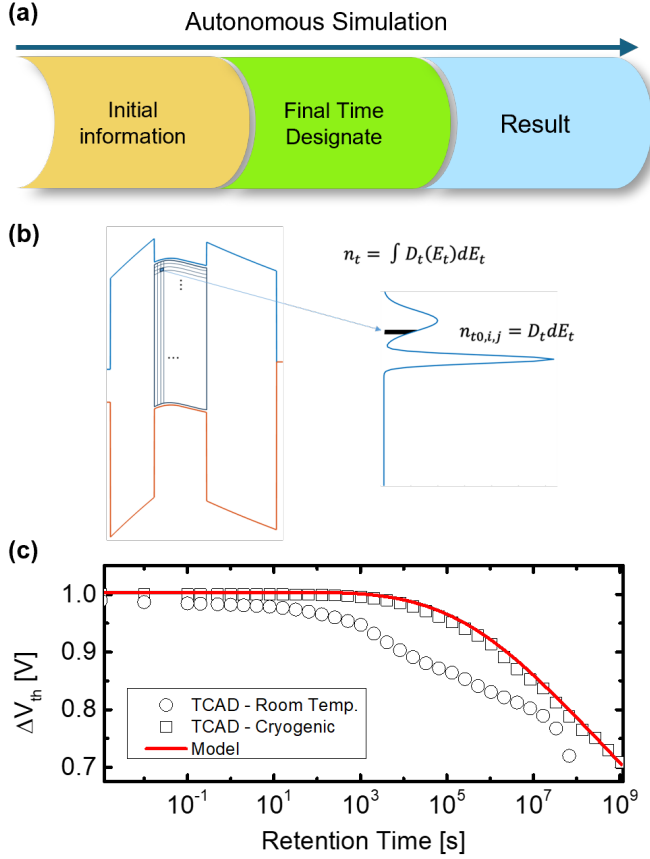


Fig. 2. (a) shows a radial scale and capacitance visualization, (b) shows the representation of ΔQ_i within the boundary condition solution, (c) shows the programming sequence of trapped electrons and holes, and (d) shows the autonomous simulation schematics.

III. SIMULATION AND RESULT

The model validation is performed using Synopsys TCAD simulations calibrated against previous retention modeling studies [1], [3]. To properly focus on the detrapping effect from the CTN layer, bandgap-engineered processes were neglected, and operating conditions such as program voltage were recalibrated for this study.

Following the erase operation, a program voltage of $1 \mu\text{s}$ was applied to all wordlines as listed in Table 1. Note that ΔV_{th} represents the threshold voltage shift from the virgin cell state, which starts from a negative value in the erased state.

According to Refaldi et.al [2], cryogenic conditions enable separation of the detrapping mechanism. To emulate cryogenic conditions during retention operation within the TCAD framework, the capture cross-section was adjusted to an extremely low value ($\sigma_n \rightarrow 0$) only during retention. This manipulation suppresses thermal electron transitions between trapped and conduction states within the CTN layer, as illustrated in Fig. 2(a), while maintaining physical consistency in other operations.

The simulation setup began with an erase operation that fully filled the CTN layer with holes using sufficient erase time [?], [?]. First, validation was conducted over a time span extending to 10 years, as shown in Fig. 2(a). The proposed

model from the previous section matches the reference TCAD simulation with less than 1% weighted mean absolute percentage error (WMAPE).

Validation of the autonomous modeling is presented in Fig. 2(c). Retention loss over time alters the band diagram; however, even with multiple refresh cycles, the autonomous model exhibits very small errors compared to full TCAD simulation, achieving less than 1% WMAPE. Thus, the autonomous simulation significantly reduces computational resources and improves calculation efficiency.

IV. CONCLUSION

This study presents an autonomous model for retention loss due to detrapping of trapped electrons. Compared to TCAD simulations calibrated with physical parameters from various prior studies, the proposed model demonstrates high accuracy with weighted mean absolute percentage error (WMAPE) below 1%. Additionally, the novelty of autonomous modeling is demonstrated through significant computational optimization, achieving results within an extremely short timeframe.

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